

Page and Script Lifecycle

Why the element was null: your script ran before the browser had parsed it.



Where a <script> runs			
<script> in <head>	<script> at end of <body>	<script defer>	<script async>
Blocks parsing and runs at once. The body does not exist yet, so getElementById returns null. This is the classic trap.	Everything above it is parsed, so selectors work. Still blocks whatever came after it.	Downloads in parallel, runs after parsing, in document order, just before DOMContentLoaded.	Runs the moment it lands: any time, any order. Only for independent scripts such as analytics.

<script type="module"> is deferred automatically: that is one reason module code just works.

So there are two fixes for a null element, and defer is the better one: defer (or type="module") on the tag, or wrap the code in document.addEventListener('DOMContentLoaded', ...). DOMContentLoaded fires when the DOM is ready; load waits for every image and stylesheet, which is usually much later.